

by the Modi government abandoning the biannual shifting of government, known as the Darbar Move, along with local issues like rising power and water bills. As a political expert says, "People are fed up of being governed by unelected leaders and bureaucrats for the past six years under central rule. There is a perception that the administration is unmindful of their concerns and a political vacuum is being felt. There has also been an overstatement of their development agenda with more of window dressing; J&K has also punched far below its weight when it comes to industrial development." The BJP may have some advantage in the fact that its principal rival in Jammu, the Congress, has yet to get its act together and put up a formidable fight against it. But then, the Grand Old Party itself may benefit on account of the widespread 'anti-incumbency' against the BJP.

PROPPING UP SEPARATISTS TO INFLATE ITS NUMBERS, AT THE COST OF MIDDLE GROUNDERS, AS THE BJP IS DOING, WILL HAVE A BLOWBACK, WARN CRITICS

DIVIDE THE VALLEY AND RULE

Anticipating losses in the Muslim-majority Kashmir Valley, the BJP had not fielded any candidate here in the general election. The party has yet to open its account in the Valley despite claiming to have strengthened its structure and membership to 700,000 in the past decade. So far, the BJP has relied on parties seen as close to New Delhi, like the J&K Apni Party and Peoples Conference. However, both the parties underperformed, drawing a mere seven per cent vote, leading to internal turmoil. Wary of being seen as the BJP's B team, the two parties have now decided against any alliance, aware that it may wipe them out of existence.

The biggest surprise, of course, was the 472,481-vote victory of AIP chief 'Engineer' Rashid from Baramulla. Experts saw the scaled-up success of the former two-time MLA from Langate in Kupwara as an expression of the voters' frustration with the established political parties as well as a vote against New Delhi. Rashid, who secured bail on September 11 to campaign for the assembly election, is fielding 34 candidates, even as the NC is questioning how he is funding his campaign. Rashid's slogan *'Tihar ka badla vote se'* has since then inspired separatists to join the fray, leading to a surge in public participation in rallies and in nominations. Some 450 candidates will be in the fray for the first two phases of the election for 50 assembly constituencies—24 in the first phase and 26 in the second.

Among these will be members of the Jamaat-e-Islami who are contesting as Independents. Banned since 2019 under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act for funding terrorism, the 5,000-strong, cadre-based Jamaat was a